



The Complete TCM Seasonal Eating Guide

*How to Nourish Your Body Through Spring, Summer,
Autumn & Winter*

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About the Author

Dr. Timothy Yeh was the President of the Yeh Center of Natural Medicine in Upland, California. Over the course of five decades, he treated more than 500,000 patients, earning a reputation as one of the most experienced practitioners of Traditional Chinese Medicine in the United States.

Dr. Yeh held a Ph.D. in Acupuncture, an Oriental Medical Doctor (O.M.D.) degree, an M.D., and a Doctor of Science (D.Sc.). He developed the Five Step Model of Systematic Natural Medicine and his proprietary diagnostic method, Causenosis™ — a system for identifying the root causes of disease rather than merely treating symptoms.

Together with Dr. Pearl Yeh, he co-founded the Yeh Center of Natural Medicine, Yeh Herbs Manufacturing, and Natural Medicine International — organizations dedicated to bringing the wisdom of classical Chinese medicine into the modern world and making it accessible to patients everywhere.

Dr. Yeh devoted his life to teaching that true health comes from understanding the whole person — body, environment, and lifestyle — and that food is one of the most powerful medicines available to us.

Introduction

Why Eating with the Seasons Matters

The earth's rotation around the sun creates predictable shifts in temperature, light, and energy throughout the year. Our bodies respond to these shifts in ways both obvious and subtle — our appetite changes, our energy levels fluctuate, and our susceptibility to certain illnesses waxes and wanes with the turning of the calendar.

For more than 4,000 years, Traditional Chinese Medicine has recognized these patterns and developed a sophisticated system for aligning what we eat with the season we're in. This isn't a new diet trend. It isn't a fad. It's a time-tested approach to nourishment that Dr. Timothy Yeh refined over 50 years of clinical practice, treating hundreds of thousands of patients.

The core insight is simple but powerful: **the same food can help you in one season and harm you in another.** A bowl of cooling mung bean soup is exactly what your body needs on a sweltering July afternoon — but it would weaken your digestion if you ate it in the middle of January. A rich lamb stew nourishes and warms you perfectly in winter — but would create excess heat if you ate it in summer.

When you eat in harmony with the seasons, your body stays balanced. Your immune system stays strong. Your digestion works smoothly. Your energy is steady. You get sick less often, and when you do, you recover faster.

This guide distills Dr. Yeh's decades of clinical wisdom into a practical, season-by-season roadmap for eating well all year long. Every food recommendation, every recipe, and every lifestyle tip in this book comes from his teachings. We've adapted them for the modern Western kitchen — every ingredient listed here can be found at your local grocery store, Whole Foods, an Asian grocery store, or online.

You don't need to overhaul your entire diet overnight. Start with the season you're in right now, try a few recipes, and notice how your body responds. The changes are often remarkable — and they begin quickly.

“A new and complete medicine for our future stands on a tripod of three sciences: Biology, Chemistry, and Physics.”

— Dr. Timothy Yeh

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CHAPTER ONE

The Foundation

How TCM Views Food

Walk into any Western doctor's office and ask about nutrition, and you'll hear about calories, macronutrients, vitamins, and minerals. This is the chemistry of food — and it's important. But Dr. Yeh taught that chemistry is only one-third of the picture.

Traditional Chinese Medicine looks at food through three distinct lenses, and understanding all three is the key to eating wisely in every season.



The Three Dimensions of Food

1. Chemistry — The Nutritional Dimension

This is what Western nutrition focuses on: vitamins, minerals, protein, carbohydrates, fats, fiber, and antioxidants. Chemistry tells you *what* a food is made of. It's the dimension you'll find on every nutrition label.

Chemistry is essential — but it's incomplete. Two foods with nearly identical nutritional profiles can have very different effects on the body, and chemistry alone cannot explain why.

2. Physics — The Energetic Dimension

Physics describes a food's energetic properties: its **internal temperature** (hot, warm, neutral, cool, or cold), its **color**, its **taste**, and its **fragrance**. These aren't metaphors — they describe real, observable effects on the body.

For example, ginger and banana have completely different internal temperatures. Ginger is warming: it raises body temperature, promotes circulation, and stimulates digestion. Banana is cooling: it reduces heat, moisturizes, and soothes inflammation. These effects occur regardless of the temperature at which you serve them.

3. Biology — The Living Dimension

Biology asks: Where did this food grow? In what climate? At what altitude? During which season? How did it develop? What is its shape and nature?

A food that grew in a hot tropical climate often has cooling properties — nature produces the antidote alongside the challenge. Root vegetables that burrow deep into the earth tend to be grounding and nourishing. Leafy greens that reach toward the sun tend to be lighter and more dispersing.

Dr. Yeh emphasized that biological context matters enormously. A tomato ripened on the vine in summer sunshine is not the same medicine as a greenhouse tomato picked in December, even if their nutritional panels look similar.

“A new and complete medicine for our future stands on a tripod of three sciences: Biology, Chemistry, and Physics.”

— Dr. Timothy Yeh



The Five Tastes and Their Organ Connections

One of the most practical teachings in TCM nutrition is the system of the Five Tastes. Each taste has a natural affinity for specific organ systems and produces specific effects in the body. When you eat all five tastes in balance every day, you nourish all your major organ systems. When you consistently over-eat one taste and under-eat others, imbalances develop.

Sweet

Stomach & Spleen Systems

Effects: Nourishing, replenishing, tonifying. The sweet taste builds energy, strengthens digestion, and soothes tension.

Common foods: Honey, rice, dates, sweet potato, corn, carrots, pumpkin, butternut squash, beets, oats, chicken, beef.

Caution: Overeating sweet foods causes energy blockage, dampness, weight gain, and sluggish digestion. The “sweet” taste in TCM refers to naturally sweet whole foods — not refined sugar.

Sour

Liver & Gallbladder Systems

Effects: Astringent, consolidating, arrests excessive discharge. The sour taste helps the body hold onto fluids and tightens tissues.

Common foods: Vinegar, lemon, grapefruit, orange, tomato, green apple, plum, fermented vegetables, yogurt.

Caution: Overeating sour foods can cause muscle spasms, stomach ulcers, joint pain, and liver overactivity.

Bitter

Heart & Small Intestine Systems

Effects: Clears heat, detoxifies, purges fire, dries dampness. The bitter taste has a natural downward and draining energy.

Common foods: Bitter melon, green tea, almonds, arugula, kale, dark chocolate, dandelion greens, coffee, celery.

Caution: Overeating bitter foods can deplete essence and dry out the body excessively.

Spicy / Pungent

Lung & Large Intestine Systems

Effects: Disperses stagnation, promotes circulation and sweating, opens the pores, moves energy outward and upward.

Common foods: Ginger, garlic, onion, black pepper, chili, mustard, radish, scallion, cinnamon, wasabi, mint.

Caution: Overeating pungent foods exhausts qi (vital energy) and can cause excessive sweating and dryness.

Salty

Kidney & Urinary Bladder Systems

Effects: Softens masses, moistens the intestines, has a downward-draining energy.

Common foods: Sea salt, seaweed, kelp, soy sauce, miso, tamari.

Caution: Overeating salty foods causes blood coagulation, high blood pressure, and can harden the arteries.

The Taste Cycles

Dr. Yeh taught that the five tastes form a *generative cycle* (sour generates bitter, bitter generates sweet, sweet generates spicy, spicy generates salty, salty generates sour) and a *controlling cycle* (each taste checks and balances another). You cannot eat only one taste group and stay healthy. The goal is to include all five tastes in your diet every day, with proportions adjusted for the season and your individual constitution.

Internal Temperature of Food

Every food has an internal, or inherent, thermal nature — regardless of the temperature at which you serve it. A slice of watermelon is cooling even when eaten at room temperature. A cup of ginger tea is warming even after it cools down.

TCM classifies foods along a thermal spectrum:

Temperature	Effect on the Body	Examples
Hot	Strongly raises body temperature, stimulates, accelerates	Chili pepper, dried ginger, cinnamon, lamb, pepper
Warm	Gently warms, promotes circulation, aids digestion	Chicken, shrimp, onion, garlic, oats, quinoa, peach
Neutral	Balanced — neither warming nor cooling	Rice, corn, sweet potato, pork, eggs, carrots, honey
Cool	Gently cools, reduces mild heat, moisturizes	Cucumber, celery, lettuce, pear, apple, tofu, barley
Cold	Strongly clears heat, detoxifies, slows metabolism	Watermelon, banana, bitter melon, mung bean, kelp

The principle is straightforward: **in warmer seasons, eat more cooling and neutral foods; in colder seasons, eat more warming and neutral foods.** This keeps your internal thermostat balanced and prevents the extremes — too much internal heat in summer, too much internal cold in winter — that lead to illness.

A Note on Internal Temperature

This topic is covered in depth in our companion ebook, *The Hidden Temperature of Food*. In this guide, we'll focus on how food temperature interacts with the seasons and provide practical guidance for each one.



The Classical Balanced Diet

Dr. Yeh's concept of a balanced diet differed significantly from the Western food pyramid. Rather than focusing primarily on macronutrient ratios, he taught that true dietary balance involves five dimensions:

1. Balance of Color

"Eat the rainbow" is popular advice in Western nutrition too — but in TCM, colors carry specific meaning. Green foods support the liver. Red foods support the heart. Yellow and orange foods support the spleen and stomach. White foods support the lungs. Black and dark blue foods support the kidneys. Eating a variety of colors daily ensures you're sending nourishment to all five major organ systems.

2. Balance of Taste

As described above, all five tastes — sweet, sour, bitter, spicy, and salty — should appear in your daily diet. The proportions shift with the seasons: more sweet in spring to support the liver, more bitter in summer to support the heart, more sour in autumn to protect the lungs, and so on.

3. Balance of Temperature

Match the thermal nature of your food to the season and to your body's current condition. Eat warming foods in cold weather and cooling foods in warm weather. If you tend to run hot, favor neutral-to-cool foods. If you tend to run cold, favor neutral-to-warm foods.

4. Balance Between Plant and Animal Kingdoms

The ideal blood pH for the human body is 7.35–7.45 — slightly alkaline. Most plant foods are alkaline-forming in the body, while most animal foods are acid-forming. Dr. Yeh recommended that the majority of your diet come from plant sources (vegetables, fruits, grains, legumes, nuts, and seeds) with smaller amounts of animal protein. A rough guideline is 70–80% plant-based, 20–30% animal-based.

5. Balance of Proportions

No single food — no matter how healthy — should dominate your diet. Variety is essential. Eating 30 or more different foods per week ensures broad nutritional coverage and prevents the imbalances that come from over-relying on any single ingredient.

Dr. Yeh's Simple Rule

If your plate has multiple colors, multiple tastes, a mix of plant and animal foods, and temperatures appropriate for the season — you're eating well. Don't overthink it. Variety and seasonal alignment are the foundation.

CHAPTER TWO

The 24 Solar Terms

Understanding Nature's Calendar

In the Western world, we think of four seasons with hard boundaries — spring starts on March 20, summer on June 21, and so on. But nature doesn't flip a switch. The transition from one season to the next is gradual, subtle, and multi-layered.

For thousands of years, Chinese agriculture and medicine have used a more refined calendar: the **24 Solar Terms** (*jié qì*). This system divides the year into 24 periods of roughly 15 days each — six per season — based on the sun's actual position in the sky. Each term describes a specific stage in nature's cycle.

You don't need to memorize all 24 terms to eat seasonally. But understanding that each season has an early, middle, and late phase — and that the transitions between seasons are the most important times to pay attention to your diet — will make your seasonal eating practice much more effective.

The Four Seasons and Their Solar Terms

Spring (February – April)

Solar Term	Approximate Dates	Meaning
Beginning of Spring	Feb 3–5	Spring energy begins to stir
Rain Water	Feb 18–20	Snow turns to rain; moisture increases
Awakening of Insects	Mar 5–7	Hibernating creatures emerge; life activates
Spring Equinox	Mar 20–22	Day and night equal; midpoint of spring
Clear and Bright	Apr 4–6	Skies clear; plants bloom
Grain Rain	Apr 19–21	Rainfall nourishes growing crops

Summer (May – July)

Solar Term	Approximate Dates	Meaning
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Beginning of Summer	May 5–7	Warmth accelerates; summer begins
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Grain Buds	May 20–22	Grains begin to ripen
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Grain in Ear	Jun 5–7	Harvest of early crops; planting of late ones
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Summer Solstice	Jun 20–22	Longest day; peak of yang energy
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Minor Heat	Jul 6–8	Heat builds but hasn't peaked
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Major Heat	Jul 22–24	Hottest period of the year
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Autumn (August – October)

Solar Term	Approximate Dates	Meaning
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Beginning of Autumn	Aug 7–9	First hints of coolness
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End of Heat	Aug 22–24	Summer heat begins to fade
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White Dew	Sep 7–9	Morning dew appears; air turns crisp
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Autumn Equinox	Sep 22–24	Day and night equal; midpoint of autumn
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Cold Dew	Oct 8–9	Dew turns cold; frost approaches
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Frost's Descent	Oct 23–24	First frost; late autumn
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Winter (November – January)

Solar Term	Approximate Dates	Meaning
Beginning of Winter	Nov 7–8	Cold arrives; nature rests
Minor Snow	Nov 22–23	Light snowfall begins
Major Snow	Dec 6–8	Heavy snow; deep winter
Winter Solstice	Dec 21–23	Shortest day; peak of yin, but yang begins to return
Minor Cold	Jan 5–7	Deep cold intensifies
Major Cold	Jan 20–21	Coldest period of the year

Practical Takeaway

Think of each season as having three phases: an *early* phase (when the previous season's energy is still fading), a *peak* phase (when the season's qualities are strongest), and a *late* phase (when the next season's energy begins to emerge). Your diet should shift gradually through these phases — not change abruptly on a single date.

CHAPTER THREE

Spring — Season of Renewal

February through April

APPROXIMATE DATES

Beginning of Spring (Feb 3–5) through Grain Rain (Apr 19–21)

ENERGY

Yang begins to rise; nature awakens and expands

KEY ORGANS

Liver & Gallbladder systems

ELEMENT

Wood

COLOR ASSOCIATION

Green

TASTE TO INCREASE

Sweet (to support and nourish the liver)

TASTE TO DECREASE

Sour (to prevent liver overactivity)

Spring is the season of awakening. After months of cold and contraction, energy begins to push upward and outward — just like seedlings breaking through soil. In TCM, spring corresponds to the **Wood element** and the **liver and gallbladder systems**.

The liver is responsible for the smooth flow of energy throughout the body. When the liver is healthy and balanced, energy circulates freely, emotions are stable, and digestion is

smooth. When the liver becomes overactive or stagnant — common problems in spring — you may experience irritability, headaches, eye problems, allergies, digestive upset, or mood swings.

Spring eating focuses on supporting the liver's natural upward and outward movement, gently detoxifying after winter, and eating lighter foods as the weather warms.

Spring Lifestyle Tips from Dr. Yeh

- **Sleep later, arise earlier.** Follow the lengthening daylight. Go to bed a little later and wake a little earlier than in winter.
- **Be active and spend time outdoors.** Walk, stretch, garden. Spring is the time to shake off winter's stillness and get the body moving.
- **Wear loose clothing.** Avoid restricting the body with tight belts, collars, or compression wear. Energy needs to expand freely in spring.
- **Practice patience and avoid anger.** Anger is the emotion most harmful to the liver. Spring is a vulnerable time for emotional flare-ups — cultivate calmness and patience.
- **Protect against wind.** In TCM, wind is the dominant climate factor in spring and can trigger headaches, allergies, and colds. Wear a light scarf on windy days.



Spring Foods: What to Eat

Spring foods should be fresh, green, lightly cooked, and upward-growing. Think sprouts, young greens, and tender vegetables — foods that mirror the energy of the season.

Vegetables

Asparagus, artichokes, pea sprouts, snow peas, spinach, dandelion greens, sprouts (bean, alfalfa), broccoli, leeks, green onions, celery, lettuce, bok choy, napa cabbage, broccoli rabe, watercress, and fresh herbs such as mint, basil, cilantro, and parsley.

Fruits

Strawberries, cherries (late spring), green apples, kiwi, lemons, limes, grapefruit.

Proteins

Chicken, fish (especially lighter white fish such as cod, sole, or tilapia), eggs, duck (its cooling nature is helpful as spring warmth builds), and shrimp.

Grains & Legumes

Barley, brown rice, oats, mung beans, lentils, split peas.

Nuts & Seeds

Pine nuts, walnuts, sesame seeds, sunflower seeds.

Special Spring Ingredients

Chrysanthemum flowers — Brew as tea. Clears heat from the liver, benefits the eyes. Available at Asian grocery stores or online.

Goji berries — Small red berries, mildly sweet. Nourish the liver and eyes. Available at most health food stores, Whole Foods, and Asian markets.

Jujube dates (Chinese red dates) — Sweet, chewy dried fruit. Nourish the blood and support digestion. Available at Asian grocery stores and online.

Tremella (white fungus) — A delicate, gelatinous mushroom. Deeply moisturizing. Available dried at Asian grocery stores and online.

Spring Foods to Avoid or Reduce

- Heavy, greasy, fried foods (they burden the liver)
- Excessive spicy or hot foods (the liver is already active and easily overheated)
- Excessive sour foods (sour constricts, which opposes spring's expansive energy)
- Cold raw foods early in spring (the body is still warming up from winter)
- Excess alcohol (directly stresses the liver)



Spring Recipes

RECIPE 1

Spring Tea

INGREDIENTS

- 1 tablespoon goji berries
- 1 tablespoon chrysanthemum flowers (dried)
- 5–6 jujube dates (Chinese red dates)
- 2–3 slices fresh lemon
- 1 teaspoon honey (to taste)
- 3 cups water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse the goji berries and jujube dates.
2. Bring water to a boil, then add goji berries and jujube dates. Reduce heat and simmer for 10 minutes.
3. Remove from heat, add chrysanthemum flowers, and let steep for 5 minutes.
4. Strain into cups. Add lemon slices and honey to taste.
5. Enjoy warm or at room temperature.

Benefits: Supports vision, nourishes the liver, gently clears heat. An ideal daily spring beverage.

RECIPE 2

Tremella Congee

INGREDIENTS

- 1 piece dried tremella (white fungus), about 15g
- ½ cup pearl barley (Job's tears)
- 6–8 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak the tremella overnight in cold water. It will expand significantly. Remove the hard base and tear into small florets.
2. Rinse the pearl barley.
3. Combine tremella, pearl barley, and water in a pot. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat to the lowest setting and simmer for 6–8 hours (a slow cooker works perfectly), or until the tremella has broken down into a silky, gelatinous consistency.
5. Stir in honey to taste before serving.

Benefits: Deeply moisturizing for the lungs and skin. Supports the nervous system and immunity. The long cooking time transforms the tremella into a collagen-rich gel that is remarkably nourishing.

RECIPE 3

Pea Sprout & Garlic Stir-Fry

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (about 10 oz) pea shoots (pea sprouts)
- 30g dried shiitake mushrooms (about 6–8 pieces)
- 1 clove garlic, minced
- Pinch of sea salt
- 1 tablespoon vegetable oil or sesame oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak the dried shiitake mushrooms in warm water for 30 minutes until soft. Squeeze out excess water and slice thinly.
2. Wash the pea shoots thoroughly and drain.
3. Heat oil in a wok or large skillet over high heat.
4. Add minced garlic and stir-fry for 15 seconds until fragrant.
5. Add sliced mushrooms and stir-fry for 1 minute.
6. Add pea shoots and stir-fry for 1–2 minutes until just wilted but still bright green.
7. Season with sea salt and serve immediately.

Benefits: Clears heat, supports liver detoxification, boosts immunity. Pea shoots are one of the quintessential spring vegetables in Chinese cuisine.

RECIPE 4

Yam Porridge

INGREDIENTS

- 150g (about $\frac{3}{4}$ cup) brown rice
- 100g (about 1 small) yam or sweet potato, peeled and cubed
- 6–8 cups water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse the brown rice until the water runs clear.
2. Peel the yam or sweet potato and cut into small cubes (about 1 cm).
3. Combine rice, yam, and water in a heavy-bottomed pot.
4. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to low and simmer for 40–60 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the rice has broken down into a thick, creamy porridge.
5. Serve warm, plain or with a drizzle of honey.

Benefits: Nourishes the spleen, stomach, lung, and kidney systems. Gentle on the digestion and known in TCM to beautify the complexion. An excellent breakfast during the spring transition.

RECIPE 5

Daikon & Brown Rice Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (about 1 cup) daikon radish, peeled and diced small
- 100g (about ½ cup) brown rice
- 6 cups water
- 1 stalk green onion, chopped
- Sea salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse the brown rice. Peel and dice the daikon into small cubes.
2. Combine rice, daikon, and water in a pot. Bring to a boil.
3. Reduce heat and simmer for 45–60 minutes until both rice and daikon are very soft.
4. Add green onion and sea salt to taste. Stir and serve warm.

Benefits: Aids digestion, helps prevent constipation, and gently clears stagnation from winter. Daikon radish is prized in TCM for its ability to move stuck energy downward and out.

RECIPE 6

Chrysanthemum & Almond Drink

INGREDIENTS

- 6g dried chrysanthemum flowers (about 1 tablespoon)
- 6g almonds (about 6–8 almonds)
- 2 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak almonds in warm water for 10 minutes and peel off the skins.
2. Bring water to a boil. Add almonds and chrysanthemum flowers.
3. Reduce heat and simmer gently for 5–10 minutes.
4. Strain, add honey to taste, and drink warm.

Benefits: Helpful for spring headaches, seasonal allergies, and high blood pressure. Cleanses and cools the liver and lung systems. Especially good during the “Clear and Bright” solar term when allergies peak.

RECIPE 7

Mung Bean Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (about ½ cup) mung beans
- 50g (about ¼ cup) azuki red beans
- 25g (about 2 tablespoons) pearl barley
- 6–8 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse all beans and barley thoroughly.
2. Combine in a pot (or slow cooker) with water.
3. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to the lowest setting.
4. Simmer for 5–7 hours, or cook overnight in a slow cooker on low, until the beans are completely soft and the liquid is thick.
5. Stir in honey before serving.

Benefits: Cleanses the liver and gallbladder. Mildly cooling — helps counterbalance the rising heat of late spring. Supports detoxification and helps clear skin breakouts.

RECIPE 8

Spring Vegetable Wontons

INGREDIENTS

- 250g all-purpose flour (or 40 store-bought wonton wrappers)
- 50g ground lean pork or beef
- 30g Chinese yam powder (available at Asian grocery stores)
- 1 cup finely chopped spring vegetables (napa cabbage, chives, or bok choy)
- 1 tablespoon soy sauce
- 1 teaspoon sesame oil
- Sea salt to taste
- Rice vinegar for dipping

INSTRUCTIONS

1. If making wrappers from scratch: Mix flour and yam powder with enough warm water to form a smooth dough. Rest 30 minutes, then roll very thin and cut into squares. Otherwise, use store-bought wonton wrappers.
2. Mix the ground meat with chopped vegetables, soy sauce, sesame oil, and salt.
3. Place a small spoonful of filling in the center of each wrapper. Wet the edges, fold into triangles, and press to seal.
4. Bring a large pot of water to a boil. Add wontons and cook until they float, about 3–4 minutes.
5. Serve in the cooking broth or drained, with rice vinegar for dipping.

Benefits: Nourishes the spleen and stomach, moistens the lung and kidney systems. The yam powder adds digestive support. A warming, satisfying meal for early-to-mid spring.

CHAPTER FOUR

Summer — Season of Abundance

May through July

APPROXIMATE DATES

Beginning of Summer (May 5–7) through Major Heat (Jul 22–24)

ENERGY

Yang at its peak; maximum heat and expansive energy

KEY ORGANS

Heart & Small Intestine systems

ELEMENT

Fire

COLOR ASSOCIATION

Red

TASTE TO INCREASE

Bitter (supports the heart, clears heat)

TASTE TO DECREASE

Spicy (don't add more heat to an already-hot season)

Summer is the season of maximum yang energy. Everything in nature is at its most active, most expansive, and most heated. In TCM, summer corresponds to the **Fire element** and the **heart and small intestine systems**.

The heart governs not only the physical circulation of blood but also the mind, consciousness, and emotional life. When summer heat becomes excessive — either from

the environment or from the foods we eat — the heart system can become agitated. This manifests as insomnia, restlessness, anxiety, palpitations, excessive sweating, and heat-related illness.

Summer eating focuses on **clearing heat, staying hydrated, protecting the heart, and eating lighter meals**. This is the season to eat more cooling foods, more fruits and vegetables, and fewer heavy, warming dishes.

Summer Lifestyle Tips from Dr. Yeh

- **Sleep slightly later, arise early.** Summer days are long — your schedule can expand with them. A brief afternoon rest (15–30 minutes) can help compensate for later bedtimes.
- **Spend more time outdoors.** Engage with the abundant energy of the season. Morning and evening are the best times to be active; avoid intense midday heat.
- **Stay calm and avoid agitation.** In TCM, excessive excitement and agitation can harm the heart. Practice calm, joyful activities rather than overstimulating ones.
- **Take it easy and relax more.** Despite the long days, summer is not a time to push yourself to exhaustion. Balance activity with rest.
- **Stay hydrated** with room-temperature or cool (not iced) water, herbal teas, and water-rich fruits and vegetables.



Summer Foods: What to Eat

Vegetables

Cucumber, tomatoes, zucchini, summer squash, bitter melon, celery, lettuce, bell peppers, corn, green beans, eggplant, watercress, mung bean sprouts, lotus root.

Fruits

Watermelon, honeydew melon, cantaloupe, peaches (warm — enjoy in moderation), berries (blueberries, strawberries, blackberries), plums, grapes, pears.

Proteins

Fish (especially lighter white fish), duck (cooling nature makes it ideal for summer), tofu, eggs, small amounts of chicken.

Grains & Legumes

Mung beans, red beans (azuki), barley, brown rice, buckwheat, pearl barley (Job's tears).

Special Summer Ingredients

Chrysanthemum tea — Cooling, clears heat from the liver and eyes. Brew dried flowers in hot water.

Green tea — Cooling, antioxidant-rich, supports the heart. Widely available everywhere.

Lotus seeds — Calms the heart, nourishes the spleen. Available dried at Asian grocery stores.

Lily bulb (dried) — Moisturizes the lungs, calms the mind. Available at Asian grocery stores and online.

Mint — Cooling, refreshing, aids digestion. Available fresh at any grocery store.

Summer Foods to Avoid or Reduce

- Excessive spicy or hot foods (peppers, raw garlic in large amounts, heavy ginger)
- Fried and heavy foods (overload an already-taxed digestive system)
- Too much red meat (warming and heavy)
- Excessive iced or frozen foods and drinks — despite the heat, ice water shocks the digestive system. Dr. Yeh taught that ice constricts blood vessels and reduces organ function. Cool or room-temperature drinks are far better for the body.
- Excessive sweet foods (create dampness and sluggishness)

One of Dr. Yeh's most memorable teachings was about iced drinks. He observed that Americans consume enormous quantities of ice water and iced beverages, especially in summer, and he believed this habit contributed significantly to digestive weakness. Cold constricts blood vessels and slows digestive enzymes. In the middle of summer, when your body is already working to manage external heat, pouring ice water into your stomach forces your digestive system to divert energy to warming the liquid before it can process it. Drink cool or room-temperature water instead.



Summer Recipes

RECIPE 1

Mung Bean & Barley Summer Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (about ½ cup) mung beans
- 50g (about ¼ cup) pearl barley (Job's tears)
- 50g (about ¼ cup) azuki red beans
- 8 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse all beans and barley thoroughly.
2. Combine in a pot or slow cooker with water.
3. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to the lowest setting.
4. Simmer overnight (or 6–8 hours in a slow cooker on low) until all beans are completely soft and the soup is thick.
5. Sweeten with honey. Serve at room temperature or slightly cool — not iced.

Benefits: The quintessential TCM summer soup. Deeply cooling, clears internal heat, reduces swelling and water retention, detoxifies. Mung beans are considered one of the most important foods for surviving hot weather in Chinese medicine.

RECIPE 2

Watermelon & Mint Refresher

INGREDIENTS

- 3 cups fresh watermelon, cubed and seeded
- 6–8 fresh mint leaves
- Juice of half a lime
- 1 cup water (optional, for a thinner drink)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blend watermelon with mint leaves and lime juice until smooth.
2. Add water if desired for a lighter consistency.
3. Serve cool (not iced). Can be strained for a smoother drink.

Benefits: Watermelon is one of the most cooling fruits in TCM — it clears summer heat, rehydrates, and supports the kidneys. Mint adds additional cooling and digestive support. A perfect afternoon drink during the Major Heat period.

RECIPE 3

Bitter Melon & Egg Stir-Fry

INGREDIENTS

- 1 medium bitter melon (about 250g)
- 3 eggs
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tablespoon soy sauce
- 1 teaspoon sesame oil
- ½ teaspoon sea salt
- 1 tablespoon vegetable oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Cut bitter melon in half lengthwise. Scoop out the seeds and white pith. Slice thinly (about 3mm).
2. Sprinkle slices with salt and let sit for 15 minutes. Rinse and squeeze out excess moisture. (This reduces the bitterness.)
3. Beat the eggs with a pinch of salt.
4. Heat vegetable oil in a wok over high heat. Add garlic, stir-fry 15 seconds.
5. Add bitter melon slices and stir-fry for 2–3 minutes until slightly softened.
6. Push the melon to the side, pour in eggs, and scramble. Mix everything together.
7. Add soy sauce and sesame oil. Toss and serve immediately.

Benefits: Bitter melon is the premier summer vegetable in TCM. Its strong bitter taste clears heat from the heart system, detoxifies the blood, and helps prevent heat-related illness. The eggs add nourishment and balance.

RECIPE 4

Smashed Cucumber & Sesame Salad

INGREDIENTS

- 2 medium cucumbers
- 2 tablespoons rice vinegar
- 1 tablespoon sesame oil
- 1 clove garlic, minced
- ½ teaspoon sea salt
- 1 tablespoon toasted sesame seeds
- Pinch of sugar (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Place cucumbers on a cutting board. Using the flat side of a knife or a rolling pin, smash the cucumbers firmly — they should crack open unevenly.
2. Tear or cut the smashed cucumber into bite-sized pieces.
3. In a small bowl, mix rice vinegar, sesame oil, minced garlic, salt, and sugar.
4. Toss the cucumber with the dressing.
5. Sprinkle with toasted sesame seeds and serve immediately.

Benefits: Cooling and refreshing. Cucumber clears heat and quenches thirst. The irregular smashed texture creates more surface area for the dressing to cling to, making each bite flavorful.

RECIPE 5

Lotus Seed & Lily Bulb Sweet Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 30g (about 2 tablespoons) dried lotus seeds
- 15g (about 1 tablespoon) dried lily bulb
- 5 cups water
- Rock sugar or honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak lotus seeds in water for 2 hours (or overnight). If they have green cores, remove them — the cores are very bitter.
2. Rinse the dried lily bulb and soak for 30 minutes.
3. Combine lotus seeds and lily bulb in a pot with water. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat and simmer gently for 1.5–2 hours until both are very soft.
5. Add rock sugar or honey to taste. Serve warm or at room temperature.

Benefits: Calms the mind, nourishes the heart system, and promotes restful sleep. This is a traditional summer dessert soup, perfect for nights when the heat makes it hard to settle down. Both lotus seeds and lily bulb are available at Asian grocery stores.

RECIPE 6

Tomato & Egg Drop Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 3 medium ripe tomatoes, cut into wedges
- 2 eggs, beaten
- 1 stalk green onion, chopped
- 2 thin slices fresh ginger
- 4 cups water or light broth
- Sea salt to taste
- 1 teaspoon sesame oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water or broth to a boil with ginger slices.
2. Add tomato wedges and simmer for 5–8 minutes until soft and the broth turns slightly orange.
3. Remove ginger slices. Season with salt.
4. Bring to a gentle boil. Slowly pour in beaten eggs in a thin stream while stirring gently — the eggs will form delicate ribbons.
5. Remove from heat. Drizzle with sesame oil, top with green onion, and serve.

Benefits: A classic Chinese comfort soup that's naturally cooling. Tomatoes clear heat and generate fluids. Eggs nourish yin. Light, easy to digest, and ready in under 15 minutes.

RECIPE 7

Corn & Red Date Congee

INGREDIENTS

- 2 ears fresh sweet corn (or 1 cup frozen corn kernels)
- ½ cup brown rice
- 6–8 red dates (jujube dates)
- 6–8 cups water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Cut corn kernels from the cob (or use frozen).
2. Rinse brown rice and red dates.
3. Combine rice, dates, and water in a pot. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat and simmer for 40 minutes, stirring occasionally.
5. Add corn kernels and continue simmering for another 15–20 minutes until the porridge is thick and creamy.
6. Serve warm.

Benefits: Nourishes the heart and spleen systems. Corn is neutral in temperature and sweet in taste — gentle and supportive. Red dates nourish the blood and calm the mind.

RECIPE 8

Chrysanthemum & Goji Berry Iced Tea

INGREDIENTS

- 2 tablespoons dried chrysanthemum flowers
- 1 tablespoon goji berries
- 4 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a boil. Add chrysanthemum flowers and goji berries.
2. Remove from heat and let steep for 10–15 minutes.
3. Strain and add honey to taste.
4. Let cool to room temperature naturally. Can be refrigerated briefly but serve cool rather than ice-cold.

Benefits: A traditional summer cooldown drink throughout China. Chrysanthemum clears heat and benefits the eyes (especially helpful for those who spend long hours at screens). Goji berries nourish the liver and add a pleasant sweetness.

CHAPTER FIVE

Autumn — Season of Harvest

August through October

APPROXIMATE DATES

Beginning of Autumn (Aug 7–9) through Frost's Descent (Oct 23–24)

ENERGY

Yang declining, Yin rising; dryness increasing

KEY ORGANS

Lung & Large Intestine systems

ELEMENT

Metal

COLOR ASSOCIATION

White

TASTE TO INCREASE

Sour (helps contract and protect lung qi)

TASTE TO DECREASE

Spicy (drying — harmful to already-dry autumn lungs)

After the exuberant outward energy of summer, autumn marks the great turning inward. Energy begins to contract, descend, and consolidate. Leaves fall, days shorten, and the air becomes drier. In TCM, autumn corresponds to the **Metal element** and the **lung and large intestine systems**.

The lungs are the most external of the internal organs — they interface directly with the outside air. They are also the most delicate, and they *hate dryness*. As autumn's dry air sets in, the lungs become vulnerable. Dry cough, scratchy throat, dry skin, cracked lips, constipation, and weakened immunity are all signs that the lungs are struggling with autumn dryness.

The number one priority in autumn eating is **moisturizing**. Every recipe, every food choice, and every lifestyle adjustment in this season should be oriented toward keeping the lungs — and the entire body — moist, supple, and protected.

Autumn Lifestyle Tips from Dr. Yeh

- **Sleep earlier, arise earlier.** Begin winding down with the shorter days. Adequate sleep protects the lungs and immune system.
- **Be calm and emotionally steady.** In TCM, sadness and grief are the emotions associated with the lungs. Autumn is naturally a reflective, sometimes melancholy season. Acknowledge these feelings but don't dwell in them.
- **Keep warm as temperatures drop.** Protect the neck and chest from cold wind, which can invade the lungs.
- **Moisturize.** Use a humidifier if the air in your home is dry. Drink warm fluids throughout the day. Apply natural moisturizers to the skin.
- **Practice gentle breathing exercises.** Deep, slow breathing strengthens the lungs and helps them adapt to the drier air.



Autumn Foods: What to Eat

The theme of autumn eating is **moisture, nourishment, and gentle warmth**. Favor foods that are naturally lubricating, white in color (which corresponds to the lungs in five-element

theory), and cooked rather than raw.

Vegetables

Pumpkin, sweet potato, carrots, daikon radish, cauliflower, mushrooms (shiitake and especially tremella), bok choy, cabbage, turnips, beets, lotus root, leeks.

Fruits

Pears (the number one autumn fruit — deeply moisturizing for the lungs), apples, figs, grapes, persimmons, pomegranates, dates, goji berries.

Proteins

Duck, pork, fish, eggs, tofu.

Grains, Legumes & Nuts

Oats, rice, millet, almonds, walnuts, pine nuts, sesame seeds (especially black sesame), black beans, white beans.

Special Autumn Ingredients

Tremella (white fungus) — The star of autumn. When slow-cooked, it becomes a rich, collagen-like gel that deeply moisturizes the lungs and skin. Available dried at Asian grocery stores and online.

Lily bulb (dried) — Moisturizes the lungs and calms the mind. Available at Asian grocery stores.

Honey — One of the best natural lung moisturizers. Use raw, unprocessed honey when possible.

Pears — TCM considers the pear the single best fruit for the lungs. Especially beneficial when cooked or steamed.

Goji berries — Nourish the liver and kidneys, support the transition into the colder months.

Autumn Foods to Avoid or Reduce

- Excess spicy and pungent foods (chili, raw garlic, wasabi) — these further dry out the lungs
- Raw, cold foods — as the weather cools, shift toward cooked and warm preparations
- Excessive caffeine — drying to the body

- Heavy fried foods — burden the lungs and large intestine



Autumn Recipes

RECIPE 1

Tremella Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 100g dried tremella (white fungus) — about 2 large pieces
- 8–10 cups water
- Honey to taste
- Optional additions: 1 pear (peeled, cubed), 2 tablespoons pearl barley, or a handful of dried fruits

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak the tremella overnight in cold water. It will expand to several times its dried size.
2. Remove the hard yellow base. Tear the tremella into small, bite-sized pieces.
3. Place in a pot or slow cooker with water. Bring to a boil, then reduce to the lowest simmer.
4. Cook for 5–7 hours (slow cooker on low overnight works perfectly) until the tremella has completely broken down into a thick, silky, gelatinous consistency.
5. If adding pear or pearl barley, add them during the last 1–2 hours of cooking.
6. Stir in honey to taste before serving.

Benefits: The ultimate autumn lung tonic. Tremella is rich in natural plant-based collagen and polysaccharides that deeply moisturize the lungs, throat, and skin. Regular consumption throughout autumn can help prevent dry cough, dry skin, and weakened immunity. This is one of Dr. Yeh's most frequently recommended autumn preparations.

RECIPE 2

Cooked Pears with Almonds

INGREDIENTS

- 2 ripe pears (any variety; Asian pears work especially well)
- 6g almonds (about 6–8 almonds), blanched
- 2 tablespoons honey
- 2 cups water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Wash the pears. Cut in half lengthwise but keep the skin on. Remove the core.
2. Place pear halves in a pot, cut side down. Add water and almonds.
3. Bring to a gentle simmer. Cover and cook for 20–30 minutes until the pears are very soft and translucent.
4. Transfer to serving bowls. Drizzle with honey and spoon the cooking liquid over the top.

Benefits: Nourishes the lungs, relieves chronic dry cough, and moisturizes the throat. Cooked pear is a classic TCM remedy that Dr. Yeh recommended frequently during the autumn months. The almonds add lung-nourishing support and a pleasant flavor.

RECIPE 3

Beef & Pumpkin Stew

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (about ½ lb) beef stew meat, cut into chunks
- 500g (about 1 lb) pumpkin or butternut squash, peeled and cubed
- 1 onion, diced
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 4 cups water or beef broth
- Sea salt and black pepper to taste
- 1 tablespoon vegetable oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Heat oil in a heavy pot over medium-high heat. Brown the beef on all sides, about 3–4 minutes.
2. Add onion and garlic. Cook for 2 minutes until fragrant.
3. Add water or broth. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to low.
4. Cover and simmer for 1 hour.
5. Add the pumpkin cubes. Continue simmering for another 45–60 minutes until both the beef and pumpkin are very tender.
6. Season with salt and pepper. Serve hot.

Benefits: Warming and nourishing as the weather turns cool. Beef tonifies qi and blood. Pumpkin nourishes the spleen and stomach, supports the digestive system, and benefits respiratory health. A hearty, grounding meal for mid-to-late autumn.

RECIPE 4

Daikon Radish Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 300g (about 10 oz) daikon radish, peeled and cubed
- 50g (about ¼ cup) corn kernels (fresh or frozen)
- 1 small white onion, diced
- 1 stalk green onion, chopped
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 5 cups water or vegetable broth
- Sea salt and black pepper to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Peel and cube the daikon radish into bite-sized pieces.
2. In a pot, sauté the white onion and garlic in a little oil for 2 minutes.
3. Add daikon, corn, and water or broth. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat and simmer for 30–40 minutes until the daikon is very tender and slightly translucent.
5. Season with salt and pepper. Garnish with chopped green onion.

Benefits: Nourishes the immune system, lung, and large intestine systems. Daikon radish is a powerful digestive aid and mucus reducer. This simple soup is especially helpful during the transition from late summer into autumn.

RECIPE 5

Carrot & Radish Honey Tonic

INGREDIENTS

- 200g (about 2 medium) carrots
- 200g (about 1 cup) daikon radish
- 400g (about 1¼ cups) raw honey

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Wash and peel the carrots and radish. Juice them using a juicer or blender (if blending, strain through cheesecloth to extract the juice).
2. Pour the combined juice into a small saucepan. Heat very gently over low heat — do not boil. Warm until slightly reduced, about 10 minutes.
3. Remove from heat and let cool to lukewarm. Stir in the honey until fully dissolved.
4. Store in a clean glass jar in the refrigerator. Take 1 teaspoon (about 5g) twice daily — morning and evening.

Benefits: A concentrated tonic for bronchitis, chronic cough, and immune boosting. This traditional preparation combines the lung-nourishing properties of carrots, the phlegm-clearing power of radish, and the moisturizing effect of honey. Can be taken throughout the autumn season as a daily supplement.

RECIPE 6

Lily Bulb & Red Date Dessert

INGREDIENTS

- 30g dried lily bulb (about 2 tablespoons)
- 30g (about 8–10) Chinese red dates (jujube dates)
- 5 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak the dried lily bulb in water for 1–2 hours until softened. Rinse and drain.
2. Rinse the red dates.
3. Combine lily bulb and water in a pot. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat and simmer for 1 hour.
4. Add red dates and continue simmering for another hour until everything is very soft.
5. Stir in honey to taste. Serve warm.

Benefits: Nourishes the lungs and supports the immune and lymphatic systems. Lily bulb is especially known for relieving chronic dry cough. Red dates nourish the blood and calm the nerves. A soothing dessert or afternoon treat during the drier weeks of autumn.

RECIPE 7

Roasted Pumpkin & Walnut Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (about 1 lb) pumpkin or butternut squash, halved and seeded
- ¼ cup walnuts
- 1 small onion, diced
- 3 cups vegetable broth
- ¼ teaspoon cinnamon
- Sea salt to taste
- 1 tablespoon olive oil

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Preheat oven to 400°F (200°C). Place pumpkin halves cut-side down on a baking sheet. Roast for 35–45 minutes until very tender.
2. While the pumpkin roasts, toast walnuts in a dry pan over medium heat until fragrant, about 5 minutes. Set aside.
3. Sauté onion in olive oil until soft, about 5 minutes.
4. Scoop the roasted pumpkin flesh into the pot with the onion. Add broth and cinnamon.
5. Blend with an immersion blender (or in batches in a regular blender) until smooth.
6. Season with salt. Serve topped with toasted walnuts.

Benefits: Pumpkin nourishes the spleen and stomach. Walnuts nourish the kidneys and brain. Cinnamon gently warms without overheating. A velvety, satisfying soup that bridges the mid-autumn to late-autumn transition.

RECIPE 8

Sesame & Honey Oatmeal

INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup rolled oats
- 2 cups warm milk, almond milk, or oat milk
- 1 tablespoon black sesame seeds (or black sesame seed powder)
- 1 tablespoon honey
- Pinch of sea salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Cook oats with milk according to package directions until creamy.
2. Stir in black sesame seeds (or powder) and a pinch of salt.
3. Transfer to a bowl and drizzle with honey.

Benefits: Deeply moisturizing — supports the lungs, skin, and hair. Black sesame nourishes the kidney system and is traditionally used to prevent premature graying and hair loss. Honey adds additional lung moisture. A warming, nourishing breakfast for autumn mornings.

CHAPTER SIX

Winter — Season of Storage

November through January

APPROXIMATE DATES

Beginning of Winter (Nov 7–8) through Major Cold (Jan 20–21)

ENERGY

Yin at its peak; conservation, storage, and inward focus

KEY ORGANS

Kidney & Urinary Bladder systems

ELEMENT

Water

COLOR ASSOCIATION

Black / Dark

TASTE TO INCREASE

Bitter (supports the kidney-heart balance)

TASTE TO DECREASE

Salty (excessive salt harms the kidneys in winter)

Winter is the season of maximum yin — the deepest quiet, the longest darkness, the greatest cold. Nature has fully contracted: trees are bare, animals hibernate, and the earth rests under frost or snow. In TCM, winter corresponds to the **Water element** and the **kidney and urinary bladder systems**.

The kidneys are considered the root of life in Chinese medicine. They store the body's fundamental essence (*jing*), govern growth and development, control the bones and teeth, and regulate the body's water metabolism. The kidneys also house our deepest reserves of energy — the reserves we draw on during times of illness, stress, or extraordinary demand.

Winter is the season to **nourish and replenish these reserves**. Rather than burning energy outward (as in spring and summer), winter eating focuses on building, warming, and storing. This is the time for hearty soups, slow-cooked stews, warming spices, and deeply nourishing foods.

If you eat well in winter, you build a foundation of strength and resilience that carries you through the entire coming year. If you eat poorly in winter — too much cold food, too many raw salads, inadequate calories — you deplete your reserves and become vulnerable to illness in spring.

Winter Lifestyle Tips from Dr. Yeh

- **Go to sleep early, wake at daylight.** Dr. Yeh recommended being in bed by 8:30 PM and rising around 5:30 AM (or whenever the sun comes up). Sleep is how the body replenishes its deepest reserves.
- **Stay warm and protect from cold.** Layer clothing. Keep the lower back, feet, and neck warm — these areas are most vulnerable to cold invasion in winter.
- **Stay indoors more.** This is nature's signal to conserve. Don't fight it. Spend more time resting, reading, and engaging in quiet, restorative activities.
- **Minimize excessive physical exertion.** Winter is not the ideal time for intense, sweat-draining exercise. Moderate movement — walking, tai chi, gentle yoga — is better than exhausting workouts.
- **Nourish and store essence.** Everything you eat, every rest you take, is an investment in next year's health. Treat winter as a period of strategic replenishment.



Winter Foods: What to Eat

Winter is THE season for building reserves. Eat heartier, richer, more warming foods. Focus on dark-colored foods (which nourish the kidneys), root vegetables, warming proteins, and bone-nourishing preparations.

Vegetables

Root vegetables (sweet potatoes, carrots, beets, turnips, parsnips), squash (butternut, acorn, kabocha), mushrooms (shiitake, black mushroom), leeks, onions, kale, cabbage, garlic (cooked).

Fruits

Dates (jujube), dried longan, chestnuts, walnuts, dried figs, citrus (oranges, tangerines, clementines), apples.

Proteins

Lamb or mutton (the number one winter meat in TCM — deeply warming and nourishing), beef, chicken, bone broth, shrimp, eggs.

Grains, Legumes & Nuts

Black beans, black rice, brown rice, oats, sweet rice (glutinous rice), barley, black sesame seeds, walnuts, chestnuts, pine nuts, red beans (azuki).

Special Winter Ingredients

Goji berries — Nourish the liver and kidneys, support vision. Available at health food stores and Asian markets.

Fresh and dried ginger — Warming, promotes circulation, supports digestion. Use generously in winter cooking.

Cinnamon — Warms the body from the inside, supports kidney yang. Use in teas, porridges, and stews.

Dried longan — Nourishes the blood and heart. Sweet, warming. Available at Asian grocery stores.

Chinese angelica (dong quai) — A warming herb that nourishes and moves the blood. Available at Asian grocery stores, health food stores, and online. Often sold as dried slices.

Bone broth — Rich in minerals and collagen. Slow-simmered bones from chicken, beef, or pork nourish the kidneys, bones, and joints.

Winter Foods to Avoid or Reduce

- Raw, cold foods and salads (your digestive system needs warmth in winter)
- Iced drinks and cold beverages
- Excessive amounts of cooling foods (watermelon, cucumber, banana, bitter melon)
- Overeating (store energy wisely — eating past fullness wastes digestive resources)



Winter Recipes

RECIPE 1

Lamb & Ginger Stew

INGREDIENTS

- 500g (about 1 lb) lamb stew meat, cut into chunks
- 30g (about a 2-inch piece) fresh ginger, sliced
- 30g Chinese angelica (dong quai), optional — available as dried slices at Asian grocery stores
- 6 cups water
- Sea salt to taste
- 2 stalks green onion, chopped (for garnish)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blanch the lamb: bring a pot of water to a boil, add the lamb pieces, and cook for 2 minutes. Drain and rinse off any scum. This removes impurities and gaminess.
2. In a clean pot, combine the blanched lamb, sliced ginger, and dong quai (if using) with 6 cups of fresh water.
3. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to a gentle simmer.
4. Cover and cook for 1.5–2 hours until the lamb is very tender.
5. Season with sea salt. Garnish with chopped green onion and serve hot.

Benefits: The quintessential winter dish in TCM. Lamb is the most warming common meat, and when combined with ginger and dong quai, this stew deeply warms the body, nourishes the blood, and tonifies kidney yang. Especially beneficial during the coldest weeks (Minor Cold and Major Cold solar terms). For a simpler version, omit the dong quai — the lamb and ginger alone are excellent.

RECIPE 2

Chestnut & Longan Porridge

INGREDIENTS

- 100g (about 10–12) chestnuts, peeled (or use pre-peeled roasted chestnuts)
- 50g (about ¼ cup) brown rice
- 30g (about 2 tablespoons) black beans
- 15g (about 1 tablespoon) dried longan
- 6–8 cups water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. If using raw chestnuts, score an X on the flat side and boil for 10 minutes. Peel while still warm. Chop roughly.
2. Rinse brown rice and black beans. Soak black beans for at least 2 hours (or overnight) for faster cooking.
3. Combine rice, black beans, and water in a pot. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat and simmer for 1 hour.
4. Add chestnuts and dried longan. Continue simmering for another hour until everything is very soft and the porridge is thick.
5. Serve warm. Can be lightly sweetened with honey if desired.

Benefits: Deeply tonifies the kidney system, strengthens digestion, and nourishes the body's deepest energy reserves. Black beans and chestnuts are both premier kidney-nourishing foods. Longan warms the heart and blood. This is a restorative breakfast or evening meal during the darkest months.

RECIPE 3

Walnuts & Chives Stir-Fry

INGREDIENTS

- 60g (about ½ cup) walnuts
- 50g (about 1 bunch) Chinese chives or garlic chives, cut into 2-inch lengths
- 1 tablespoon sesame oil
- Pinch of sea salt

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring a small pot of water to a boil. Blanch the walnuts for 1 minute, then drain. This removes any bitterness from the skins.
2. Heat sesame oil in a wok or skillet over medium-high heat.
3. Add walnuts and stir-fry for 1–2 minutes until lightly golden and fragrant.
4. Add chives and stir-fry for another 1–2 minutes until just wilted.
5. Season with salt and serve immediately.

Benefits: Supports kidney energy and brain function. Walnuts are one of the top kidney-nourishing nuts in TCM and are traditionally associated with supporting memory and cognitive function. Chinese chives are warming and support yang energy. A quick, flavorful side dish for winter dinners.

RECIPE 4

Longan & Lotus Seed Soup

INGREDIENTS

- 15g (about 1 tablespoon) dried longan
- 15g (about 1 tablespoon) dried lotus seeds
- 5–6 red dates (jujube dates)
- 4 cups water
- Honey or rock sugar to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Soak lotus seeds for 2 hours. If they have bitter green cores, remove them.
2. Rinse longan and red dates.
3. Combine all ingredients with water in a pot. Bring to a boil.
4. Reduce heat and simmer gently for 2 hours until the lotus seeds are very soft and the broth is sweet and fragrant.
5. Add honey or rock sugar to taste. Serve warm.

Benefits: Supports memory and cognitive clarity. Nourishes spleen energy and blood. Calms the nerves and promotes restful sleep. Longan is one of the most warming and blood-nourishing dried fruits in TCM. This gentle, sweet soup is ideal for winter evenings.

RECIPE 5

Black Sesame & Black Bean Cereal

INGREDIENTS

- 10g (about 1 tablespoon) black sesame seed powder
- 10g (about 1 tablespoon) black bean powder (or finely ground roasted black beans)
- 8g (about 2 teaspoons) taro powder (available at Asian grocery stores, or substitute sweet potato)
- 1 cup warm soy milk or milk of choice

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Combine all powders in a bowl or mug.
2. Pour warm soy milk over the powders and stir vigorously until smooth.
3. Let sit for 2–3 minutes to thicken slightly. Stir again and drink warm.

Benefits: A powerful kidney-nourishing drink. Black sesame and black beans are both associated with preventing premature graying and hair loss, supporting kidney function, and regulating blood pressure. The black color corresponds directly to the kidney system in five-element theory. A quick, convenient winter breakfast or snack.

RECIPE 6

Red Date & Sweet Rice Congee

INGREDIENTS

- 250g (about 1¼ cups) sweet rice (glutinous rice)
- 10 red dates (jujube dates)
- 50g (about ¼ cup) barley
- 40g (about 3 tablespoons) Chinese yam powder (or 1 small yam, peeled and cubed)
- 8 cups water
- Honey to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Rinse sweet rice, barley, and red dates. Soak barley for 2 hours for faster cooking.
2. Combine barley and water in a pot. Bring to a boil and simmer for 30 minutes.
3. Add sweet rice and red dates. Continue simmering for another 30–40 minutes, stirring occasionally, until thick and creamy.
4. Stir in Chinese yam powder (or add fresh yam cubes during the last 20 minutes of cooking).
5. Cook for a final 5–10 minutes. Sweeten with honey and serve warm.

Benefits: Deeply nourishing for the immune system. Lifts energy and warms the body. Sweet rice is warming and sticky — it adheres to and strengthens the digestive lining. Red dates nourish the blood. Chinese yam tonifies the spleen, lung, and kidney systems. An excellent restorative meal during illness recovery.

RECIPE 7

Bone Broth with Root Vegetables

INGREDIENTS

- 1–1.5 kg (2–3 lbs) beef or chicken bones (marrow bones, knuckles, backs, or a mix)
- 2 medium carrots, cut into chunks
- 2 small turnips, peeled and quartered
- 1 medium sweet potato, cubed
- 1 onion, quartered
- 3–4 slices fresh ginger
- 2 tablespoons rice vinegar or apple cider vinegar
- 10–12 cups water
- Sea salt to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Blanch the bones: place in a pot of cold water, bring to a boil, and cook for 5 minutes. Drain and rinse. This removes impurities.
2. Place blanched bones in a large pot or slow cooker. Add onion, ginger, vinegar, and water. The vinegar helps extract minerals from the bones.
3. Bring to a boil, then reduce heat to the lowest possible simmer. Cook for 4–8 hours (the longer, the richer). Skim any foam that rises to the surface.
4. During the last hour of cooking, add the root vegetables (carrots, turnips, sweet potato).
5. When done, strain the broth if desired, or serve with the vegetables. Season with sea salt.

Benefits: Rich in calcium, magnesium, collagen, and gelatin — all of which nourish the kidneys, strengthen the bones and joints, and support the immune system. Root vegetables add grounding, warming energy. This is one of the most deeply nourishing preparations you can make in winter — a cup a day provides remarkable support.

RECIPE 8

Winter Herbal Tea Blend

INGREDIENTS

- 3–4 thin slices fresh ginger root
- 1 small stick cinnamon bark (about 3 inches)
- ½ teaspoon fennel seeds
- 4–5 dried peppermint leaves (or 2–3 fresh)
- 3 cups water
- Honey to taste (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Bring water to a boil. Add ginger slices. Reduce heat and simmer for 20–30 minutes — hard roots need the longest cooking time.
2. Add cinnamon bark and continue simmering for 10–20 minutes.
3. Add fennel seeds and simmer for another 5–10 minutes.
4. Remove from heat. Add peppermint leaves and let steep for 2–3 minutes (mint should be steeped briefly to preserve its aromatic oils).
5. Strain and serve warm. Add honey if desired.

Benefits: Warming, digestive, and protective. Ginger and cinnamon warm the core and promote circulation. Fennel supports digestion and reduces bloating. Peppermint adds a fresh note and aids the stomach. A wonderful daily winter tea — especially good after meals or before bed.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Year-Round Neutral Foods

The “Always Safe” Foods for Every Season

While seasonal eating means adjusting your diet throughout the year, there is a category of foods that are welcome in any season: **neutral-temperature foods**. These foods are neither warming nor cooling, making them gentle and balanced for almost everyone, almost all the time.

If you're ever unsure what to eat, or if you're going through a seasonal transition and want to play it safe, reach for the neutral foods. They support the body without pushing it in any extreme direction.

Category	Neutral Foods
Vegetables	Black mushroom, broccoli, cabbage, carrot, cauliflower, corn, cooked daikon radish, napa cabbage, potato, shiitake mushroom, string beans, sweet potato, taro root, tremella (white fungus), lily bulb
Fruits	Apple, dates (jujube), dried fig, fresh fig, grape, mango
Proteins	Abalone, eggs, pork, quail
Grains, Legumes & Nuts	Azuki red beans, black-eyed peas, broad beans, brown rice, buckwheat, oats, peanuts, pine nuts, sesame seeds (brown and black), soybeans, sweet rice (glutinous rice), walnuts
Other	Honey, sea salt

How to Use This List

Neutral foods form the *base* of your diet in every season. Then layer in seasonal foods on top:

- **Spring:**
Add green, upward-growing vegetables and gently cooling foods
- **Summer:**
Add cooling fruits and vegetables to balance the heat
- **Autumn:**
Add moisturizing foods — especially pears, tremella, and honey
- **Winter:**
Add warming meats, roots, and dark-colored kidney-nourishing foods

The neutral foods provide stability; the seasonal foods provide the specific support your body needs at that time of year.

Notice that several of the most important TCM pantry staples appear on this list: brown rice, eggs, sweet potato, carrots, honey, dates, and sesame seeds. These are foods you can stock year-round and build any seasonal meal around.

CHAPTER EIGHT

How to Transition Between Seasons

Navigating the In-Between

In the West, we tend to think of seasons as four distinct blocks with clean boundaries. But nature doesn't work that way — and neither does your body. The transitions *between* seasons are actually the most important and most vulnerable periods of the year.

Dr. Yeh taught that the majority of seasonal illnesses — colds, flu, allergies, digestive upset, fatigue — occur not in the middle of a season, but during the shift from one to the next. Your body is adapting to new temperatures, new humidity levels, and new energy patterns. If your diet doesn't shift gradually with these changes, you're more likely to get sick.

The Two-Week Transition Window

Give yourself approximately two weeks on either side of a seasonal boundary to transition your diet. Don't go from heavy winter stews to cold salads overnight when spring arrives. Don't jump from cooling summer foods to warming autumn dishes in a single meal.

Transition	Approximate Timing	What to Do
Winter → Spring	Late January – mid February	Gradually lighten meals. Reduce heavy meats. Begin adding more green vegetables. Keep meals warm but less rich.
Spring → Summer	Late April – mid May	Gradually introduce more cooling foods. Reduce cooking times (less slow-cooking, more stir-frying). Add more raw fruits as the weather warms.
Summer → Autumn	Late July – mid August	Begin reducing cold and raw foods. Start adding moisturizing foods (pears, honey, tremella). Transition from salads to soups.
Autumn → Winter	Late October – mid November	Increase warming foods. Add more animal protein and heartier preparations. Shift from light soups to rich stews and bone broths.

Bridge Foods

These are foods that work well in both the season you're leaving and the season you're entering. Lean on them during transitions:

Transition	Bridge Foods
Winter → Spring	Brown rice, oats, carrots, sweet potato, eggs, chicken, goji berries, dates
Spring → Summer	Barley, mung beans, celery, cucumber, green tea, tofu, fish, strawberries
Summer → Autumn	Pears, honey, rice, pumpkin, sweet potato, lily bulb, eggs, apples
Autumn → Winter	Walnuts, black beans, mushrooms, ginger, chestnuts, brown rice, root vegetables

Signs Your Body Is Struggling with a Transition

Pay attention to these signals — they often indicate that your diet hasn't kept pace with the seasonal shift:

- **Fatigue and low energy** that doesn't improve with rest
- **Digestive upset** — bloating, loose stools, or constipation
- **Catching colds** easily, or a cold that lingers
- **Skin problems** — dryness, breakouts, or sensitivity
- **Mood changes** — irritability, anxiety, or sadness that feels disproportionate
- **Sleep disruption** — difficulty falling asleep or waking during the night
- **Allergies** flaring up (especially during winter-to-spring and summer-to-autumn)

If you notice these patterns, look at what you're eating. Chances are, your diet is still aligned with the *previous* season rather than the current one. Adjust gradually, focusing on the bridge foods and the recommendations for the new season.

Dr. Yeh's Transition Rule

“When in doubt, eat neutral.” During the most uncertain days of a seasonal transition, stick to neutral-temperature foods from Chapter 7 — brown rice, sweet potato, eggs, carrots, apples. These will support your body without pushing it in the wrong direction while you feel out the new season’s energy.

CHAPTER NINE

Season-at-a-Glance Quick Reference

Your Seasonal Cheat Sheets

Keep these one-page summaries handy — on your refrigerator, in your phone, or bookmarked in this guide. They distill each season's key principles into a format you can reference at a glance.

Spring — Season of Renewal

KEY DETAILS

- **Dates:** Feb – Apr
- **Organs:** Liver & Gallbladder
- **Element:** Wood
- **Color:** Green
- **Increase:** Sweet taste
- **Decrease:** Sour taste

TOP 10 FOODS

1. Asparagus
2. Spinach
3. Pea shoots
4. Sprouts
5. Leeks & green onions
6. Strawberries
7. Barley
8. Goji berries
9. Chrysanthemum tea
10. Mint & fresh herbs

TOP 5 TO AVOID

1. Heavy fried foods
2. Excess spicy foods
3. Excess sour foods
4. Cold raw foods (early spring)
5. Alcohol

3 QUICK RECIPES

1. Goji & Chrysanthemum Tea
2. Pea Shoot Stir-Fry
3. Yam Porridge

LIFESTYLE TIP

Get outside. Move your body. Wear loose clothing. Cultivate patience.

Summer — Season of Abundance

KEY DETAILS

- **Dates:** May – Jul
- **Organs:** Heart & Small Intestine
- **Element:** Fire
- **Color:** Red
- **Increase:** Bitter taste
- **Decrease:** Spicy taste

TOP 10 FOODS

1. Mung beans
2. Watermelon
3. Cucumber
4. Bitter melon
5. Tomatoes
6. Lotus seeds
7. Green tea
8. Tofu
9. Duck
10. Barley

TOP 5 TO AVOID

1. Excess spicy/hot foods
2. Fried & heavy foods
3. Too much red meat
4. Iced/frozen drinks
5. Excess sweets

3 QUICK RECIPES

1. Mung Bean Summer Soup
2. Watermelon Mint Refresher
3. Tomato Egg Drop Soup

LIFESTYLE TIP

Stay calm. Hydrate with cool (not iced) drinks. Rest during peak heat.

Autumn — Season of Harvest

KEY DETAILS

- **Dates:** Aug – Oct
- **Organs:** Lung & Large Intestine
- **Element:** Metal
- **Color:** White
- **Increase:** Sour taste
- **Decrease:** Spicy taste

TOP 10 FOODS

1. Pears
2. Tremella (white fungus)
3. Honey
4. Pumpkin
5. Sweet potato
6. Almonds
7. Lily bulb
8. Daikon radish
9. Figs
10. Sesame seeds

TOP 5 TO AVOID

1. Excess spicy/pungent foods
2. Raw, cold foods
3. Excess caffeine
4. Heavy fried foods
5. Drying herbs & spices

3 QUICK RECIPES

1. Tremella Soup
2. Cooked Pears with Almonds
3. Sesame Honey Oatmeal

LIFESTYLE TIP

Moisturize inside and out. Sleep earlier.
Keep warm. Breathe deeply.

Winter — Season of Storage

KEY DETAILS

- **Dates:** Nov – Jan
- **Organs:** Kidney & Urinary Bladder
- **Element:** Water
- **Color:** Black / Dark
- **Increase:** Bitter taste
- **Decrease:** Salty taste

TOP 10 FOODS

1. Lamb
2. Bone broth
3. Black beans
4. Walnuts
5. Chestnuts
6. Ginger
7. Sweet potato
8. Black sesame
9. Goji berries
10. Red dates

TOP 5 TO AVOID

1. Raw, cold foods & salads
2. Iced drinks
3. Cooling fruits (watermelon, banana)
4. Overeating
5. Excess salt

3 QUICK RECIPES

1. Lamb & Ginger Stew
2. Bone Broth with Root Vegetables
3. Black Sesame Cereal

LIFESTYLE TIP

Sleep early. Stay warm. Conserve energy.
Build reserves for the year ahead.

The 24 Solar Terms — Seasonal Calendar

This calendar maps the traditional Chinese solar terms to their approximate Western calendar dates. Use it as a guide for when to begin shifting your diet each season.

Season	Solar Term	Approx. Dates	Dietary Focus
SPRING	Beginning of Spring	Feb 3–5	Begin lightening winter diet
	Rain Water	Feb 18–20	Add more green vegetables
	Awakening of Insects	Mar 5–7	Support liver with sweet foods
	Spring Equinox	Mar 20–22	Peak spring eating — all greens
	Clear and Bright	Apr 4–6	Address allergies with chrysanthemum
	Grain Rain	Apr 19–21	Begin summer transition
SUMMER	Beginning of Summer	May 5–7	Introduce cooling foods
	Grain Buds	May 20–22	Eat lighter meals
	Grain in Ear	Jun 5–7	Increase bitter foods for heart
	Summer Solstice	Jun 20–22	Peak cooling: mung bean soup daily
	Minor Heat	Jul 6–8	Focus on hydration
	Major Heat	Jul 22–24	Maximum cooling; avoid all hot foods

Season	Solar Term	Approx. Dates	Dietary Focus
AUTUMN	Beginning of Autumn	Aug 7–9	Start moisturizing diet
	End of Heat	Aug 22–24	Transition from cool to neutral foods
	White Dew	Sep 7–9	Pears and tremella daily
	Autumn Equinox	Sep 22–24	Peak moisturizing; reduce all spicy
	Cold Dew	Oct 8–9	Add warming elements gradually
	Frost's Descent	Oct 23–24	Begin winter transition
WINTER	Beginning of Winter	Nov 7–8	Introduce warming foods and stews
	Minor Snow	Nov 22–23	Increase warming proteins (lamb, beef)
	Major Snow	Dec 6–8	Rich broths and bone soups
	Winter Solstice	Dec 21–23	Peak nourishing: lamb stew, black foods
	Minor Cold	Jan 5–7	Deep warming; ginger tea daily
	Major Cold	Jan 20–21	Maximum warming; begin spring prep

CHAPTER TEN

Your Seasonal Eating Action Plan

Getting Started Today

You don't need to master all four seasons at once. The best way to begin is to focus on the season you're currently in and build from there. Here's your step-by-step plan.

Step 1: Start with Your Current Season

Turn to the chapter for the season you're in right now. Read the overview, look at the food lists, and pick 2–3 recipes that appeal to you. That's your starting point.

Step 2: The One-Week Seasonal Eating Challenge

Your 7-Day Challenge

- **Day 1–2:** Make one recipe from your current season's chapter. Notice how it makes you feel.
- **Day 3–4:** Swap one “avoid” food with one “eat more” food. For example, if it's autumn, replace your morning coffee with chrysanthemum or goji berry tea.
- **Day 5–6:** Try to include all five tastes in a single day's eating. Pay attention to what's missing.
- **Day 7:** Cook a second seasonal recipe. Reflect on how your energy, digestion, and mood have changed — even in just one week.

Step 3: Stock Your Seasonal Pantry

Keep these foundation items on hand year-round, then add seasonal ingredients as needed:

Year-Round Staples

- Brown rice, oats, barley
- Honey (raw, unprocessed)
- Sesame oil and sesame seeds
- Soy sauce
- Rice vinegar
- Fresh ginger and garlic
- Green tea
- Dried goji berries
- Dried red dates (jujube dates)
- Mung beans and azuki red beans

Seasonal Add-Ons

Season	Add to Your Pantry
Spring	Chrysanthemum flowers, tremella, fresh mint & basil, mung beans
Summer	Dried lotus seeds, dried lily bulb, chrysanthemum tea, green tea
Autumn	Tremella, dried lily bulb, extra honey, pears, almonds, black sesame
Winter	Dried longan, cinnamon sticks, fennel seeds, chestnuts, black beans, dong quai (optional)

Step 4: Where to Find Asian Ingredients

Most of the recipes in this guide use ingredients available at any grocery store. For the specialty TCM ingredients, here's where to look:

- **Asian grocery stores** (99 Ranch, H Mart, Mitsuwa, or your local Asian market) — the best source for tremella, dried lily bulb, lotus seeds, dried longan, chrysanthemum flowers, jujube dates, dong quai, Chinese yam powder, and mung beans.
- **Whole Foods / health food stores** — often carry goji berries, mung beans, black sesame seeds, and sometimes chrysanthemum tea.
- **Amazon** — all of the specialty ingredients listed above are available online. Search by the English name.
- **Your regular grocery store** — should have everything else: fresh ginger, garlic, sesame oil, tofu, barley, brown rice, seasonal produce, and all the proteins.

Start Simple

If the specialty ingredients feel overwhelming, start with just two:

goji berries

and

red dates

. These two ingredients appear in recipes across all four seasons, they're easy to find, and they're a wonderful introduction to TCM food therapy. Add them to your morning oatmeal, steep them in hot water for tea, or toss them into soups and porridges.

A Final Word

Seasonal eating is not about perfection. It's about awareness and gradual alignment. Even small changes — one cup of goji tea in spring, one bowl of mung bean soup in summer, one cooked pear in autumn, one pot of bone broth in winter — can make a meaningful difference in how you feel.

Dr. Timothy Yeh spent fifty years refining these principles in clinical practice, and he saw their effects in hundreds of thousands of patients. The wisdom is proven. The ingredients are accessible. The recipes are simple. All that remains is for you to begin.

Eat with the seasons. Nourish your body. Build a foundation of health that lasts.

Disclaimer

This guide is for educational and informational purposes only. It is not intended to be a substitute for professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always seek the advice of your physician or other qualified health provider with any questions you may have regarding a medical condition. Never disregard professional medical advice or delay in seeking it because of something you have read in this ebook. The information in this guide is based on Traditional Chinese Medicine principles and the clinical experience of Dr. Timothy Yeh. Individual results may vary.

Other Titles in the Yeh Center E-Book Collection

The Hidden Temperature of Food: Your Guide to the Thermal Nature of What You Eat

The Five Organ System Reset: A TCM Guide to Restoring Balance from the Inside Out

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